

Guide 63 — Library Assistant and Library Technician

Controlled English working master — Version 2.0

Review date: August 20, 2026

License: CC BY-NC-SA 4.0

What this work is

Library assistants and library technicians help people find, borrow, return, organize, access, and use library materials and services. They may work in public, school, university, corporate, government, archive, or other information-service settings.

The title matters. In the United States and Canada, assistant/clerical work and technician work are not treated as the same occupation. Technician roles generally involve more formal library or information-technology training and may include more complex cataloguing, reference, acquisition, or archive-support duties. Assistant roles more often emphasize circulation, shelving, clerical support, basic patron service, and routine records.

Neither role should automatically be described as equivalent to a professional librarian. Duties, credentials, collection types, systems, privacy requirements, accessibility responsibilities, copyright rules, and permitted decisions vary by employer and jurisdiction.

Before paying for training or accepting a job, compare the actual posting, employer policies, supervision model, technology stack, collection type, and local requirements.

What you may do

Depending on the employer, training, supervision, and local rules, duties may include:

- issuing and receiving books, media, devices, or other library materials;
- shelving, sorting, filing, labeling, and organizing collections;
- helping patrons locate books, periodicals, audiovisual materials, maps, documents, and approved digital resources;
- providing routine information about library services, hours, accounts, loans, holds, fines, programs, and equipment;
- conducting basic manual or computerized searches under approved procedures;

- supporting cataloguing, classification, metadata entry, acquisitions, serials, interlibrary loan, or archive processing when trained and assigned;
- maintaining circulation, acquisition, inventory, loan, return, and other authorized records;
- assisting with library programs, displays, communications, events, reading activities, outreach, or community services;
- helping patrons use approved computers, printers, scanners, catalogues, databases, accessibility tools, and digital-library systems;
- preparing materials for repair, storage, withdrawal, transfer, or preservation according to institutional procedures;
- reporting damaged materials, equipment problems, privacy concerns, cybersecurity incidents, safety hazards, or patron conflicts through the approved escalation process; and
- documenting work accurately and factually.

Good support makes library services more accessible and reliable while keeping professional, legal, privacy, copyright, and institutional decisions with the people authorized to make them.

What this role must not be presented as

Do not describe a library assistant or technician as having authority that the role does not carry.

Do not independently:

- claim the status or professional authority of a librarian, archivist, records officer, legal adviser, copyright specialist, or privacy officer unless separately qualified and formally assigned;
- promise that a person has a legal right to copy, digitize, distribute, reproduce, or publish protected material;
- override institutional copyright, licensing, records, privacy, cybersecurity, or collection-management policies;
- disclose patron borrowing history, account data, identity information, credentials, internal records, or licensed-content details without authorization;
- alter access permissions, disable security controls, bypass authentication, or investigate suspected cyber incidents outside your assigned scope;
- certify that a library, website, collection, service, or facility is legally compliant with accessibility requirements unless that authority is formally part of your role;
- make binding acquisition, deaccession, preservation, archival, records-retention, or classification decisions when those decisions belong to designated professionals; or

- represent employer-specific training, a short course, or informal experience as a universal license or professional credential.

When the boundary is unclear, stop and ask the responsible supervisor, librarian, manager, privacy lead, IT/security team, copyright contact, or other authorized professional.

Work environment and physical demands

Library work can look quiet from the outside, but many roles involve constant movement and public contact.

Typical demands may include:

- standing and walking for extended periods;
- shelving books at different heights;
- moving carts, boxes, media, supplies, or equipment;
- using step stools or ladders where employer procedures allow;
- repetitive scanning, keyboarding, labeling, lifting, and sorting;
- assisting many patrons with different levels of digital literacy, language ability, disability, or urgency;
- working evenings, weekends, school schedules, or public-service shifts; and
- responding calmly to conflicts, distressed patrons, damaged property, disruptive behavior, or emergency situations.

Physical work should remain non-procedural in this guide. Follow employer training and safety rules for lifting, ladders, shelving, moving equipment, storage areas, emergency response, and facility hazards.

Patron privacy, records, and confidentiality

Library workers may handle sensitive information, including names, addresses, contact details, borrowing records, account status, search requests, computer-use records, school or university identifiers, device information, payment records, and internal service notes.

Practical safeguards include:

- access only the information needed for assigned duties;
- use approved library devices, accounts, email, messaging, and databases;
- verify identity and authorization before changing account information or releasing records;
- keep screens, printouts, passwords, conversations, and circulation records private;

- do not retain patron data in personal notes, personal devices, or unapproved cloud services;
- follow institutional retention, disposal, and incident-reporting rules;
- avoid discussing patron activity in public areas or on social media; and
- report suspected account compromise, phishing, malware, or unauthorized disclosure promptly.

Local privacy law and institutional rules vary. This guide does not provide individualized legal advice.

Copyright and licensed-resource boundaries

Libraries work with copyrighted books, articles, images, recordings, databases, software, digital collections, archives, and licensed resources.

In the United States, Section 108 of the Copyright Act provides specific exceptions for qualifying libraries and archives under defined conditions. Those exceptions are conditional; they are not blanket permission to copy, scan, digitize, distribute, post, or share protected works.

Library assistants and technicians should:

- follow institutional copyright and licensing procedures;
- distinguish between public-domain, licensed, open-access, and copyright-protected material;
- avoid promising patrons that a requested use is legally permitted when the question is uncertain;
- escalate complicated copying, digitization, reproduction, publication, or rights questions; and
- respect database, ebook, streaming, software, and vendor-license restrictions.

Accessibility and inclusive service

Libraries serve people with different disabilities, literacy levels, languages, ages, cultural backgrounds, and levels of digital access.

Depending on the role, support may include:

- helping patrons locate large-print, audio, captioned, screen-reader-compatible, or other accessible materials;
- explaining library services in plain language;
- assisting with approved accessibility features on library computers or digital platforms;
- improving signage, forms, instructions, or service interactions when authorized; and

- escalating accessibility barriers that require technical, policy, procurement, or facilities changes.

Do not assume that all patrons with the same disability need the same support. Ask respectfully and follow institutional procedures. Do not claim independent legal accessibility certification authority unless that is formally part of your role.

Skills employers may value

Employers often value:

- customer service and calm communication;
- accuracy and attention to detail;
- reading, writing, numeracy, and basic research skills;
- digital literacy and comfort with library systems;
- organization and records discipline;
- ability to follow procedures consistently;
- confidentiality and sound judgment;
- cultural humility and inclusive communication;
- teamwork with librarians, technicians, administrators, educators, IT staff, and community partners;
- willingness to learn catalogues, circulation systems, databases, metadata practices, and local procedures;
- problem recognition and appropriate escalation;
- reliable attendance and time management; and
- bilingual or multilingual communication where relevant.

Do not claim certified interpretation, translation, cataloguing, archival, privacy, cybersecurity, or accessibility credentials you do not hold.

Education and entry pathways

United States

The U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics distinguishes:

- **Library Technicians — SOC 25-4031**
- **Library Assistants, Clerical — SOC 43-4121**

BLS reports that library technicians typically need a **postsecondary certificate or other nondegree award**, while library assistants typically need a **high school diploma or equivalent** and short-term on-the-job training.

A practical entry sequence is:

1. Search local postings using both assistant and technician titles.

2. Separate routine circulation/clerical duties from technician-level cataloguing, reference, metadata, archive, or systems responsibilities.
3. Record the actual education, experience, software, schedule, background-check, language, and physical requirements.
4. Compare public community-college, workforce, employer, and library-system training before paying a private provider.
5. Build supervised experience through libraries, schools, museums, archives, community centers, literacy programs, records offices, or public-service roles.
6. Apply only to roles that match your actual training and experience.

Canada

Canada separates the occupations more explicitly.

Library and public archive technicians — NOC 52100 generally require completion of a **two- to three-year college program in library and information technology**. Government of Canada Job Bank states that the occupation is not regulated according to its current records.

Library assistants and clerks — NOC 14300 generally require completion of **secondary school**. Job Bank likewise states that the occupation is not regulated according to its current records.

Employer expectations can still vary by province, institution, collection type, language, union environment, and technology platform.

Colombia

SENA's Observatorio Laboral y Ocupacional Colombiano identifies **CNO 1351 — Auxiliares de biblioteca**.

Official functions include orienting users, supporting cataloguing, lending and receiving materials, shelving and organizing collections, conducting reference searches, maintaining records, and supporting programs, inventories, communications, and bibliographic-material handling.

This is an assistant-level occupational pathway. It should not be presented as equivalent to a professional **bibliotecólogo** credential or as universal authority to perform professional librarian functions.

Public-policy and continuing-education resources from the Ministry of Education and Biblioteca Nacional de Colombia can support skills development, but a current course should be verified at the provider before spending money or assuming employer recognition.

Latin America and the Caribbean

Titles, professional roles, public-library systems, education pathways, and regulated credentials vary across the region.

Use OIT/Cinterfor and national public training institutions as locators, then verify the actual employer requirement, cost, recognition, and legal scope in the country where you plan to work.

Current wage and outlook snapshot

United States

BLS May 2024 median hourly wages:

- Library technicians: **\$19.22/hour**
- Library assistants, clerical: **\$17.31/hour**
- Combined profile median: **\$18.05/hour**, or **\$37,540 per year**

For the combined group, BLS projects employment to decline **7% from 2024 to 2034**, while still projecting about **25,800 openings per year** on average because of replacement needs.

These are national labor-market figures, not earnings or employment guarantees.

Canada

Government of Canada Job Bank currently reports:

- Library and public archive technicians — national median **C\$28.00/hour**
- Library assistants and clerks — national median **C\$23.17/hour**, with published national range figures of **C\$15.80 low / C\$23.17 median / C\$34.00 high**

Prospects and wages vary by province and territory.

Colombia

The controlled research pass identified an official occupational classification for **CNO 1351 — Auxiliares de biblioteca**, but did not establish a directly comparable current national official wage series for the exact combined Guide 63 title. Do not invent one. Use current SENA Agencia Pública de Empleo and other verified employer postings for local market intelligence, while treating individual postings as examples rather than national benchmarks.

Free-first and low-cost training strategy

Before paying for a private certificate:

1. Review 15–20 current local job postings.
2. Separate assistant requirements from technician requirements.
3. Identify which requirements are mandatory, preferred, or employer-specific.
4. Check public colleges, workforce programs, library systems, SENA, and employer training first.
5. Compare tuition, materials, transport, software, exam, and schedule costs.
6. Verify that target employers actually recognize the credential.
7. Avoid debt for training that is not requested by the roles you want.
8. Get job-placement or earnings claims in writing and treat guarantees skeptically.

Funding and public training locators

United States

CareerOneStop and American Job Centers can help identify public workforce services and WIOA-eligible training. Eligibility, approved providers, local priorities, and funding vary. WIOA support is not guaranteed.

Community colleges, public libraries, state library systems, municipal employers, and universities may also offer low-cost training, volunteering, internships, tuition support, or paid entry roles.

Canada

Compare provincial student aid, public college programs, employment services, library-system training, and employer-supported education. Confirm eligibility directly with the responsible public program before enrolling.

Colombia and Latin America

In Colombia, begin with SENA, the Agencia Pública de Empleo, Biblioteca Nacional de Colombia, and relevant public education or library networks. In other Latin American countries, use OIT/Cinterfor to identify the national public training body and then verify current offerings directly.

Employer support and work-based development

Ask employers about:

- paid onboarding;

- circulation-system and catalogue training;
- cataloguing or metadata training;
- privacy and records handling;
- copyright and licensed-resource procedures;
- patron de-escalation and conflict response;
- accessibility tools and inclusive service;
- cybersecurity awareness;
- archives or preservation handling where relevant;
- tuition assistance or reimbursement; and
- advancement from assistant to technician or from technician to other library/information roles.

Responsible use of AI

AI can support routine work, but only within employer policy and data-handling rules.

Potential low-risk uses may include:

- drafting non-confidential public notices;
- brainstorming program ideas;
- suggesting plain-language wording;
- creating first-pass metadata suggestions for later human review;
- translation support for non-sensitive public content; and
- summarizing public-domain or openly licensed material when permitted.

Do not place confidential patron information, borrowing histories, passwords, internal records, licensed database content, unpublished collections, restricted archives, or other protected data into unapproved AI systems.

Do not treat AI output as authoritative for copyright, privacy, cataloguing, archival description, legal compliance, accessibility certification, or factual reference answers. Verify important results with approved sources and qualified staff.

Cybersecurity and account safety

Library workers commonly use circulation systems, email, public-access computers, databases, vendor portals, shared drives, and cloud services.

Basic safeguards include:

- use unique approved credentials;
- follow multi-factor authentication requirements;
- lock screens when unattended;

- do not share passwords;
- recognize phishing and social-engineering attempts;
- avoid unknown links, attachments, and removable media;
- use approved software and storage locations;
- report suspected compromise promptly; and
- escalate technical or forensic work rather than attempting out-of-scope investigation.

A practical 30-day starter plan

Days 1-7

- Collect 15-20 current local postings.
- Separate assistant and technician roles.
- Note recurring education, software, language, schedule, and physical requirements.
- Identify which local libraries, colleges, schools, archives, or public agencies hire entry-level staff.

Days 8-14

- Compare your current skills with the postings.
- Practise basic catalog searching, file organization, spreadsheet use, customer service, and plain-language communication.
- Review public privacy, copyright, accessibility, and cybersecurity guidance relevant to library work.

Days 15-21

- Choose one free or low-cost skills gap to address.
- Update your resume with accurate customer-service, records, digital, research, language, or public-service experience.
- Seek supervised library, literacy, archive, school, museum, or community-service experience where practical.

Days 22-30

- Apply to roles that match your real qualifications.
- Prepare examples showing accuracy, service, confidentiality, teamwork, organization, and appropriate escalation.
- Ask employers about onboarding, systems training, advancement, and tuition support.

Advancement

Possible pathways include:

- library assistant to senior assistant;

- assistant to library technician after additional education or experience;
- circulation, acquisitions, serials, cataloguing, digital services, outreach, accessibility, archives, or records support;
- supervisory support roles; and
- further education toward librarian, archivist, records-management, information-science, or related professional roles where required.

Advancement depends on employer structure, education, experience, language, technology, local professional requirements, and available openings.

Scam and overclaim warnings

Be cautious when a provider promises:

- guaranteed library employment;
- guaranteed wages;
- a universal license that does not exist;
- automatic professional-librarian status from a short course;
- guaranteed government funding;
- guaranteed placement without employer verification; or
- a credential that target employers do not request.

Pause before spending money. Verify the provider, credential, refund policy, recognition, total cost, and local employer demand.

Official sources used for this controlled revision

- U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics — Library Technicians and Assistants
[Source link](#)
- U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics — Occupational Projections and Characteristics
[Source link](#)
- U.S. Copyright Office — Section 108
<https://www.copyright.gov/docs/section108/>
- Government of Canada Job Bank — Library and public archive technicians, NOC 52100
[Source link](#)
- Government of Canada Job Bank — Requirements, NOC 52100
[Source link](#)
- Government of Canada Job Bank — Library assistants and clerks, NOC 14300
[Source link](#)
- Government of Canada Job Bank — Wages, NOC 14300
[Source link](#)

- SENA Observatorio Laboral y Ocupacional Colombiano — CNO 1351
[Source link](#)
- SENA Observatorio — CNO 1351 functions
[Source link](#)
- Ministerio de Educación Nacional — PNLEO
[Source link](#)
- Biblioteca Nacional de Colombia — La biblioteca pública que queremos
[Source link](#)

Limitations and assurance boundary

This guide is career and training information, not legal, copyright, privacy, accessibility, cybersecurity, employment, or financial advice.

Requirements, wages, job duties, funding, technologies, and public programs change. Verify current local information before applying, enrolling, paying, copying protected material, handling sensitive records, or making decisions that require professional authority.

This controlled revision does not claim independent human certification, professional translation certification, accreditation, accessibility certification, legal review, or guaranteed employment or earnings.